

HOW COMMUNITIES CAN STOP DESTRUCTIVE DEVELOPMENT PROJECTS IN TAJIKISTAN

INTRODUCTION & FRAMEWORK

Community action shapes what happens to the rivers, valleys, and water of Tajikistan — but this guide must begin with unusual honesty and unusual caution, because Tajikistan is among the hardest places in this series to oppose a project from within. Tajikistan is a mountainous, landlocked, authoritarian state, ruled by one president since 1992, where independent civil society is rated "closed," where human-rights defenders and journalists are imprisoned and attacked, and where most people, in the words of those who monitor the country, live in a climate of fear in which they would not dare to openly oppose a project. And the project that dominates the country's future is one of the largest in the world: the **Rogun Dam**, planned to be the tallest dam on earth, rising on the Vakhsh River, costing more than eight billion dollars, expected to displace tens of thousands of people, to flood an internationally protected floodplain, and to reduce the flow of the **Amu Darya** — the great river of Central Asia — on which millions downstream in Afghanistan, Turkmenistan, and Uzbekistan depend. There is no landmark victory to point to, and the dam is pressing ahead. But the levers, running almost entirely from outside, are real.

Because Tajikistan's great project is a transboundary mega-dam financed by international development banks, the levers that matter are almost entirely external, and they are real. The distinctive lever is the **financiers' safeguard policies and accountability mechanisms**: the development banks financing the dam are bound by social and environmental safeguards, and maintain complaint and accountability mechanisms — such as the World Bank's Inspection Panel — to which affected people's concerns can be carried from safer ground. The **transboundary water law and the downstream states** are a second: the Vakhsh feeds the Amu Darya, shared with Afghanistan, Turkmenistan, and Uzbekistan, so the international law of shared rivers and the downstream nations' concern are a genuine lever. The **international heritage and wetland significance** of the protected floodplain the dam would flood — the Tigrovaya Balka reserve, a Ramsar wetland of international importance and a candidate for World Heritage listing — opens a further international channel. And the **international coalitions and documentation** carry the affected people's concerns, and the record of the resettlement's rights violations, from safety. These tools are general — the financier-accountability, transboundary-law, heritage, and coalition levers reach any internationally-financed transboundary project, with the Rogun dam the central case. But these tools have grave limits, and this guide states them plainly. Opposition inside Tajikistan is dangerous, and open protest against the regime's signature project is close to impossible: civil-society space is closed, defenders and journalists are jailed, and the resettlement of tens of thousands has already brought documented rights violations, with families given land but no houses and inadequate compensation, and little safe way to complain. The dam is the regime's prestige project, decades in the making, and the government is committed to it. The environmental assessment has been criticised as outdated and incomplete, and the project is pressing ahead — this is not a story of anyone stopping it. So the work must run entirely from outside — external, documentary, coalition-led — and above all protect everyone inside absolutely, never exposing anyone to the regime. And the honest prize is the financiers held to their safeguards, the downstream states and heritage bodies engaged, the resettlement's harms documented and pressed — from outside, carried by international coalitions, and protecting everyone inside. Above all, protect the people.

The Whole Strategy in One Idea

You cannot safely or openly oppose the regime's signature project from within, and you must never endanger anyone inside. What can be done runs almost entirely from outside: hold the international development banks to their own social and environmental safeguards through their complaint and accountability mechanisms; press the transboundary law of the shared Amu Darya and the concern of the downstream states; invoke the international heritage and wetland significance of the floodplain the dam would flood; and carry the affected people's documented concerns through international coalitions — all from safer ground, and protecting everyone inside absolutely.

Be Honest About Which Fight You're In

Tajikistan is among the hardest and most dangerous settings in this guide, and honesty about that is the first and gravest discipline. Opposition inside is dangerous and open protest close to impossible; civil-society space is closed and defenders jailed; the resettlement has already brought documented rights violations with little safe way to complain; the dam is the regime's committed prestige project; and it is pressing ahead. This is not a fight for domestic confrontation. It is external, documentary, coalition-led work whose realistic prize is the financiers held to their safeguards, the downstream states and heritage bodies engaged, and the harms documented and pressed — while everyone inside is protected absolutely.

HOW THE SYSTEM WORKS

Who Actually Decides

Domestic power is closed and committed to the dam, so the decisions a careful effort can reach run almost entirely outside: the **international development banks** financing the dam, bound by safeguards and complaint mechanisms; the **downstream states and the transboundary water law**; the **international heritage and wetland bodies**; and the **international coalitions and human-rights organisations** that carry the case. Nothing runs safely through open domestic opposition. Map the external decision-makers, and never seek to organise openly inside, before spending a week on it.

How the Project Moves — and Where You Jump In

The dam moves through the government's commitment and the international financiers' money and safeguards. You enter not by opposing it openly inside — which is dangerous — but from outside: through the financiers' safeguard and complaint mechanisms; through the transboundary law and the downstream states; through the international heritage and wetland channels; and through the international coalitions that carry the affected people's documented concerns. Enter externally, through the financiers and the shared river, and protect everyone inside.

Follow the Money and the Permissions

Follow the money: which international development banks fund the dam, and what safeguard policies and complaint mechanisms bind them. Follow the water: the Vakhsh feeding the Amu Darya, and the downstream states' rights under the law of shared rivers. Follow the harm: the resettlement's documented rights violations, the flooded floodplain, the inadequate assessment. Follow the heritage: the protected wetland the dam would drown. The leverage lies in the financiers' safeguards, the transboundary law, the heritage significance, and the coalitions.

Who's Supposed to Be Watching

Domestic oversight is closed and captured, so the watchers a careful case engages are the international development banks and their accountability mechanisms, the downstream states and the transboundary institutions, the international heritage and wetland bodies, and the international human-rights and environmental coalitions. The financiers' own safeguards and complaint panels give the external watchers real handles, from outside.

QUICK REFERENCE: SUCCESS RATES

No effort inside Tajikistan safely or openly stops the regime's signature dam, and honesty requires saying so plainly — the space is closed and the project committed. What the external tools can deliver is the financiers held to their safeguards, the downstream states and heritage bodies engaged, and the harms documented and pressed. The single most decisive move is **holding the international development banks to their own safeguards through their complaint and accountability mechanisms**, because the financiers are bound by their own policies and answer to a complaint panel, and because that pressure can be applied from outside without endangering anyone inside. The financiers' safeguards are the distinctive lever; the transboundary law and downstream states the second; the heritage significance and coalitions the reach. The realistic prize is accountability and pressure from outside, not a domestic stop.

STEP 1: TARGET IDENTIFICATION

Ask five questions, all external. **What is the harm?** — the dam's displacement, the flooded floodplain, the reduced Amu Darya, the rights violations. **Who finances it?** — the international development banks, bound by safeguards. **What law reaches it?** — the transboundary law of the shared river, the downstream states. **What heritage does it flood?** — the protected wetland and its international significance. **How is everyone inside protected?** — the overriding question. Pick the harm the financiers' safeguards, the transboundary law, or the heritage significance can reach safely, from outside.

STEP 2: DOCUMENTATION — HOW TO BUILD AN UNASSAILABLE CASE

Build the case carefully, entirely from outside. **Layer one: the harm** — the displacement and rights violations, the flooded floodplain, the reduced downstream flow, the inadequate assessment, documented through international monitoring and safely gathered testimony. **Layer two: the safeguard and the law** — the financiers' safeguard policies, the transboundary water law, the heritage protections the project breaches or strains. **Layer three: the channel and the safety** — which financier mechanism, downstream state, heritage body, or coalition to engage, and the absolute discipline of never exposing anyone inside. A case built on the financiers' own safeguards and the law of the shared river, carried from outside, is one that can pressure the responsible parties and keep everyone safe.

WHAT TO GATHER, AND WHERE TO FIND IT

Gather the **harm record**: the resettlement's documented rights violations, the flooded floodplain, the reduced downstream flow, the assessment's flaws. Gather the **money record**: the international development banks, their safeguard policies, their complaint mechanisms. Gather the **law record**: the transboundary water law, the downstream states' rights. Gather the **heritage record**: the protected wetland's international and Ramsar significance. Gather the **coalition record**: the international

human-rights and environmental organisations. Gather the **safety discipline**: confirm nothing exposes anyone inside.

STEP 3: BUILDING THE EXTERNAL COALITION

The coalition here is entirely external, because open domestic organising is dangerous. Build it from the **international human-rights and environmental organisations** that carry affected people's concerns from safety; the **downstream states and transboundary advocates**; the **international heritage and wetland bodies**; and the **diaspora and safely-gathered affected voices**. Frame everything around the financiers' safeguards, the shared river, and the documented harms; never organise openly inside; and protect everyone inside absolutely.

STEP 4: THE FINANCIERS' SAFEGUARDS, THE SHARED RIVER & THE HERITAGE — WORKING ENTIRELY FROM OUTSIDE

Set expectations honestly: the levers are real but external and constrained, so the prize is accountability and pressure, not a domestic stop.

The Financiers' Safeguards and Accountability

The distinctive lever is the **financiers' safeguard policies and accountability mechanisms**: the development banks financing the dam are bound by social and environmental safeguards and maintain complaint mechanisms — such as the World Bank's Inspection Panel — to which the affected people's documented concerns can be carried from safety. Hold the financiers to their own safeguards.

The Transboundary Law and the Downstream States

The **transboundary water law and the downstream states** are a second lever: the Vakhsh feeds the Amu Darya, shared with Afghanistan, Turkmenistan, and Uzbekistan, so the law of shared rivers and the downstream nations' concern are real. Engage the transboundary law and the downstream states.

The Heritage and the Coalitions

The **international heritage and wetland significance** of the protected floodplain, and the **international coalitions and documentation** that carry the affected people's concerns, complete the external toolkit. Pursued together — the financiers' safeguards, the transboundary law, and the heritage and coalitions — these levers press the case from outside, while protecting everyone inside.

TURNING YOUR EVIDENCE INTO ARGUMENTS

Tailor the case, always externally and carefully. **For the international development banks**: here is a project breaching your own social and environmental safeguards, and affected people bringing a complaint. **For the downstream states**: here is a shared river whose flow the dam would cut. **For the heritage and wetland bodies**: here is an internationally significant floodplain the dam would drown. **For the coalitions**: here are documented rights violations to carry from safety. **For the world**: here is a mega-dam whose harms cross borders and breach the financiers' own rules. **The golden rule**: hold the financiers to their safeguards, press the transboundary law and downstream states, invoke the heritage, carry it through coalitions — and never expose anyone inside.

STEP 5: MEDIA STRATEGY

Media must be handled with the greatest care, and entirely through external and coalition channels. Frame any attention around **the financiers' broken safeguards and the shared river**: a mega-dam breaching the international banks' own social and environmental rules, cutting a river millions downstream depend on, and displacing tens of thousands — never in a way that exposes anyone inside. Carry it through the international press, the human-rights and environmental coalitions, and the downstream states' concern. A few cautions govern everything: never expose anyone inside; work only from outside; and let the financiers' own safeguards, the transboundary law, and the documented harms carry the weight.

EMAILS & LETTERS

Keep every message external, safeguard- and law-grounded, and absolute in protecting everyone inside.

8A — To an international development bank: set out the project's breach of your social and environmental safeguards, and the affected people's complaint.

8B — To the bank's accountability mechanism: carry the affected people's documented concerns to the complaint panel.

8C — To a downstream state: raise the reduced flow of the shared Amu Darya.

8D — On the transboundary law: invoke the law of shared rivers against the dam's downstream harm.

8E — To a heritage or wetland body: document the threat to the internationally significant protected floodplain.

8F — To an international coalition: coordinate the external campaign and the safe carriage of affected voices.

8G — On the resettlement: present the documented rights violations, gathered safely.

8H — To the international public: summarise the mega-dam's cross-border harms and broken safeguards — exposing no one inside.

IF YOU HAVE LITTLE TIME OR FEW RESOURCES: THE RAPID-FIRE VERSION

The first 48 hours: identify the financiers and their safeguard and complaint mechanisms; document the harm and the transboundary and heritage stakes; write the one-page external case. **The fastest-moving levers**: the financiers' safeguards and complaint mechanisms, and the transboundary law. **Emergency action**: where the financiers are engaged, their complaint mechanism and the downstream states are the sharpest, safest handles, all from outside. Throughout, never expose anyone inside, and work only externally.

WHEN THE SYSTEM IS TILTED

The field here is not merely tilted but closed and dangerous, with the regime committed to its signature dam. Recognise it plainly and accept the aim — not a domestic stop, but the financiers held to their safeguards, the downstream states and heritage bodies engaged, the harms documented and pressed. Lean only on the external levers: the financiers' safeguards and complaint mechanisms, the transboundary law and

downstream states, the heritage significance, the international coalitions. And accept the honest limits — the space is closed, the project committed, the dam pressing ahead — while still pressing the case from outside and protecting everyone inside.

WHEN IT'S ACTUAL REPRESSION — AND WHO IS AT RISK

Here the danger is not hidden corruption but a closed, authoritarian state that jails defenders and journalists and answers dissent with force. Respond only through the **entirely external channels**: the financiers' safeguards and complaint mechanisms, the transboundary law and downstream states, the heritage bodies, the international coalitions. Never through open domestic opposition. **On safety and care**: this is the guide's most important note, and it governs everything. Tajikistan jails human-rights defenders and journalists, and its people live in a climate of fear — pursuing any of this from inside carries grave risk to liberty and safety. Keep the effort external, documentary, and coalition-led; prefer the financier, transboundary, heritage, and coalition channels entirely from outside; never organise openly inside; gather any affected testimony only through safe, trusted channels; and protect everyone inside absolutely. Protection is the governing rule.

INTEGRATION & TIMELINE: RUNNING ALL FIVE STEPS TOGETHER

The steps run in parallel, entirely from outside. The documented harm feeds the financiers' complaint, the transboundary case, and the heritage claim at once; the international coalitions carry it; nothing exposes anyone inside. A rough timeline: **weeks one to four**, assemble the harm record and the financiers' safeguards; **months two onward**, carry the complaint to the financiers' mechanism, engage the downstream states and heritage bodies, and mobilise the coalitions; **through the long external effort**, sustain the pressure and the documentation. The core discipline: external, safeguard- and law-grounded, coalition-carried, and absolute in protecting everyone inside.

FINAL ASSESSMENT

Tajikistan is among the hardest and most dangerous grounds in this guide, and this guide does not pretend otherwise. It does not claim the regime's signature dam can be safely or openly opposed from within, or that a domestic victory exists, or that the project is not pressing ahead — none of that is true, and the danger to anyone inside is grave. What it claims is real: that the international development banks financing the dam are bound by their own social and environmental safeguards and answer to complaint mechanisms to which affected people can bring their case; that the Vakhsh feeds the shared Amu Darya, so the transboundary law and the downstream states are a genuine lever; that the protected floodplain the dam would flood holds international heritage and wetland significance; and that international coalitions can carry the affected people's documented concerns from safety. These tools are general, reaching any internationally-financed transboundary project, with the Rogun dam the central case. The levers are external, and the prize is the financiers held to their safeguards, the downstream states and heritage bodies engaged, and the harms documented and pressed — not a domestic stop. For a closed state whose mega-project answers to international financiers and the law of shared rivers, that external work — carried by coalitions from outside, and protecting everyone inside absolutely — is not a lesser ambition. It is the only responsible and effective one.